

PITCHING

A pitcher's job is to get the batter out. He or she needs to make it difficult for the batter to hit the ball – known as a strike – or place the ball so that the batter will hit it where it will be caught easily.

1 WIND UP

The pitcher starts with his back foot on the pitching rubber and then raises his front leg to waist height.

2 STRIDE

He then plants his front foot firmly on the ground and swings his pitching arm back.

3 PITCH

Finally, the pitcher throws his arm forwards, releasing the ball when the arm is fully extended.

PITCH STYLES

The way that the pitcher grips or releases the ball can affect the speed, force, and angle of the pitch. Here are some common pitches.

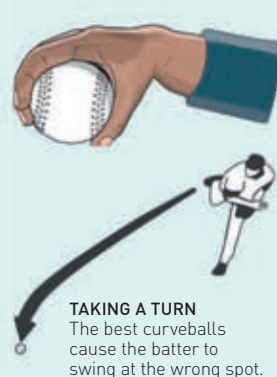
FASTBALL

This is a popular pitch. Two fingers over the top of the ball allow it to be released at great speed.



CURVEBALL

A twist of the wrist gives this pitch topspin, which causes it to curve downwards at the last moment.



SLIDER

Gripped slightly off-centre, the slider is not quite as fast as a fastball, or as curved as a curved ball.



KNUCKLEBALL

The most difficult to learn, the knuckleball is gripped with two fingers on the top of the ball and pitched straight.



A CATCHER WILL SUGGEST OR "CALL" A PITCH STYLE TO THE PITCHER, BASED ON THE BATTER'S STANCE

STRIKE!

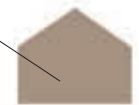
The pitcher must pitch the ball into the area known as the "strike zone". If the batter does not swing at all, misses the ball, or hits it into foul territory, the umpire at the home plate will call "strike". If a batter has three strikes, he or she is out, and it is the next batter's turn.

STRIKE ZONE

The strike zone is the area above the home plate between the batter's knees and the mid-point of his or her torso.



Home plate



Bat completes a full swing

Head up to check where the ball has gone

Hips rotate to generate power

BATTING

Batting requires strength, skill, timing, and the ability to out-think the pitcher. Most professional players are considered to be good hitters if they can safely hit three out of ten pitches.

1 STANCE

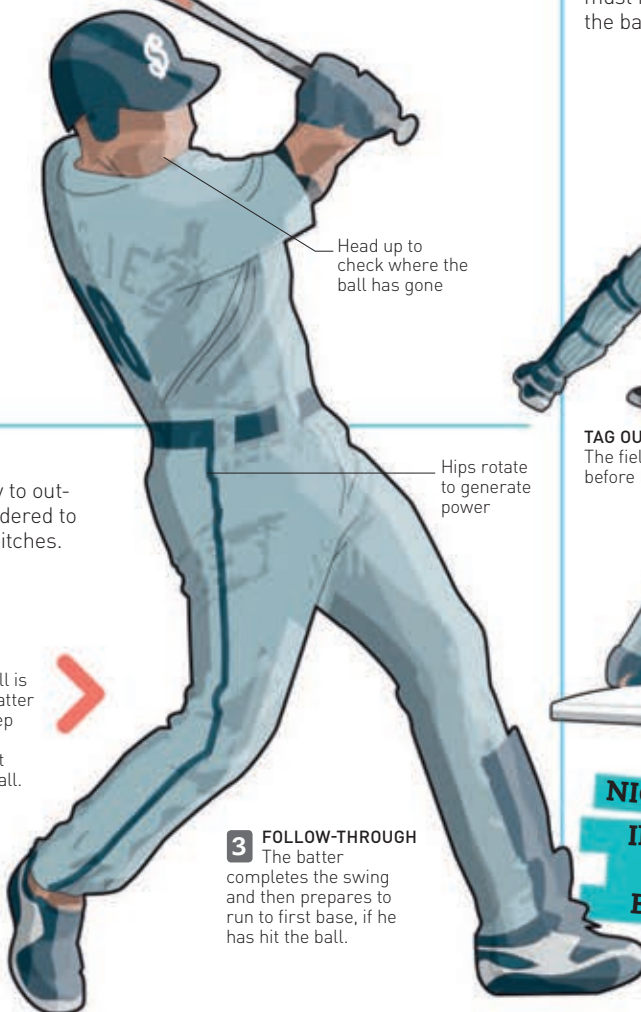
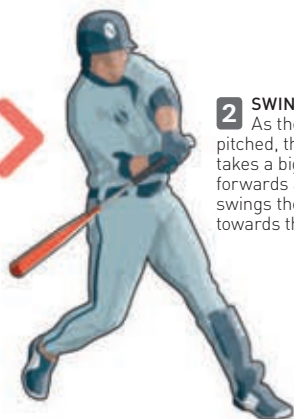
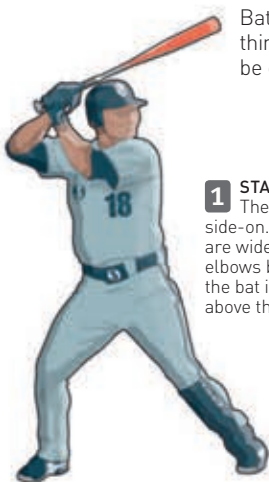
The batter stands side-on. The legs are wide apart, the elbows bent, and the bat is raised above the head.

2 SWING

As the ball is pitched, the batter takes a big step forwards and swings the bat towards the ball.

3 FOLLOW-THROUGH

The batter completes the swing and then prepares to run to first base, if he has hit the ball.



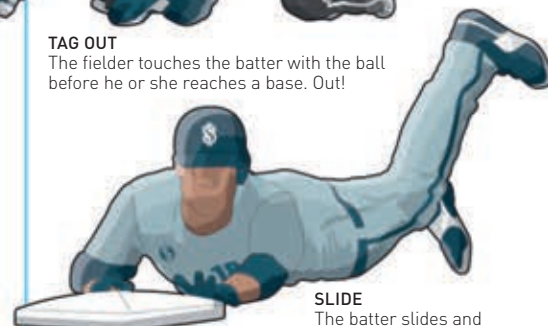
BASE RUNNING

As soon as the batter hits the ball, they need to start running to first base. However, they must reach the base before a fielder can throw the ball to a team-mate standing on the base.



TAG OUT

The fielder touches the batter with the ball before he or she reaches a base. Out!



SLIDE

The batter slides and touches the base before the base fielder can receive the ball. Safe!

NICKNAMES FOR A HOME RUN INCLUDE: DINGER, TATER, LONGBALL, MOON SHOT, BOMB, OR GOPHER BALL

WORLD SERIES

Every year the winners of the American League and the winners of the National League compete in a set of games, known as the World Series. These teams have won the most World Series, including some, such as the Giants, who have played in more than one city.

- 1 **NEW YORK YANKEES** 27
- 2 **ST LOUIS CARDINALS** 11
- 3 **PHILADELPHIA/OAKLAND/KANSAS CITY ATHLETICS** 9
- 4 **BOSTON RED SOX AND NEW YORK/SAN FRANCISCO GIANTS** 8
- 5 **BROOKLYN/LOS ANGELES DODGERS** 6
- 6 **CINCINNATI REDS AND PITTSBURGH PIRATES** 5
- 7 **DETROIT TIGERS** 4

INTERNATIONAL BASEBALL

Baseball was dropped as an Olympic sport in 2008 and the last Baseball World Cup was held in 2011, so the most prestigious national competition is the World Baseball Classic. Launched in 2006, Japan won the first two competitions, but the Dominican Republic were victorious in 2013.